

BLUEPRINT OF A BREAKTHROUGH

Tiruppur Tamizhans, the TNPL 2025 champion, built its **title run** on clarity at the auction table, trust in youth, and a core belief in its bowling unit.

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The recently concluded Tamil Nadu Premier League season delivered a compelling underdog story, as the Idream Tiruppur Tamizhans defied the odds to clinch a historic maiden title.

Under the leadership of R. Sai Kishore, the Tamizhans crafted a campaign defined by clarity, cohesion, and quiet belief. Their ascent culminated in a commanding win over defending champion Dindigul Dragons in the final — a fitting exclamation mark to a season few had foreseen.

“Looking at the composition of the team in the beginning, or when we just finished the auction, if somebody had told us that we would be reaching the finals, I would have happily accepted that. But looking at the whole tournament, the boys turned up very well,” said RX Muralidhar,

Tiruppur’s head coach, in an exclusive chat with *Sportstar*.

Muralidhar’s conviction in the group was forged well before the first ball was bowled — at the auction table. While retaining a trusted core, including the prolific opening duo of Tushar Raheja — the tournament’s Orange Cap winner — and VP Amith Sathvik, the Tamizhans astutely added emerging, largely unheralded talent to their ranks.

Their bowling unit, marshalled by the seasoned T. Natarajan, proved decisive. He was complemented by the pace of Ragupathy Silambarasan and the breakout brilliance of Esakkimuthu.

Silambarasan finished with 10 wickets, while Esakkimuthu — the tournament’s surprise package — bagged 14, routinely rattling stumps with sizzling yorkers. In a sign of the team’s depth, four of their bowlers

ended the campaign with double-digit wicket tallies.

“I realised that bowlers are the ones who win you tournaments. I wanted bowlers who can not only contain the run flow, but pick wickets regularly. And the way our bowlers repaid the faith I had in them is gratifying,” Muralidhar said.

He added, “I wouldn’t say we got all our targets but we had a clear cut plan on how to structure our squad. We picked players who could fit into those roles and it was easier for them as well to go out there and explore.”

With several players impressing throughout the tournament, it was no surprise to see a steady stream of Indian Premier League scouts at TNPL venues. Among them were former India pacers T.A. Sekhar and Vinay Kumar, the latter representing Mumbai Indians. A performer like Esakkimuthu, whose stump-hunting